Pivotum

PIVOTUM CAREER VALUE GUIDE · FALL 2026

Is an Architecture Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

5.0

AI EXPOSURE · LICENSED ARCHITECT / DESIGN LEAD

where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOR-CODED

THE FINDING   EXPOSURE   PROTECTION   METHOD & HONESTY

Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in an architecture degree or training, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study architecture" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether *you* are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where architecture sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Architecture isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 4.7 to 7.6, and almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you — chiefly, whether you steer toward the site and the stamp. The second half of this guide is those moves.

And one thing specific to architecture. The AI answer here is reasonably good. The honest problems with this career are the ones the profession has had for decades — the length of the path, and the pay relative to that length. Those matter more than the score does, and since you're already on the path, the useful response to them isn't reconsidering — it's finishing well and aiming at the protected end.

The short answer

Yes at the licensed, client-facing end — but architecture is a long degree, and the value only arrives if the whole path is completed.

Licensed architecture scores **5.0** out of 10. Production drafting scores **7.6**. Construction administration — the site-based end — scores **4.7**.

The stamp, the site and the client relationship are real protection. But the drafting years that traditionally filled the path to licensure are being automated out from under it, and the path itself is the longest of any design profession — which is why *which end you steer toward* is the work now, not just landing anywhere.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Construction administration / site	4.0	4.3	**4.7**	+0.7	Moderate
Licensed architect / design lead	4.3	4.6	**5.0**	+0.7	Moderate
Specialist (sustainability, computational)	4.8	5.2	**5.5**	+0.7	Moderate
Technical / BIM coordination	5.8	6.3	**6.7**	+0.9	Moderate–High
Production drafting	6.1	7.0	**7.6**	+1.5	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, *licensed engineering scores* 4.0, *construction management* 3.3, *and graphic design production* 8.4.

Read the table this way: the same split that runs through this whole index — the site holds, the desk drifts. Site-based construction administration is the best-protected work in the profession, and production drafting moved +1.5 in three years. Your job, from here, is to move up the table toward the site and the signature — not to hope the table moves.

Why licensed architecture holds up — the six factors

How much of this job can AI already do?	**8.0**
How hard will it be to land that first job?	**4.5**
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	**5.0**
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	**7.5**
Does the law require a licensed human?	**8.5**
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	**7.5**

EXPOSURE RAISES THE SCORE   PROTECTION LOWERS IT

Here's how licensed architecture answers them. Knowing *why* the licensed and site-based tiers hold while production drafting sits at 7.6 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

A substantial and growing share of the desk work.

Drafting and documentation sets. Massing studies and floor-plan options. Rendering and visualization. Code checking and compliance. Specification drafting. Proposals and admin.

Adoption is already substantial — a majority of architecture firms report using AI-driven software, and around 30% of design and drafting *tasks* are estimated to be automatable. Note the wording: tasks, not jobs.

The AIA's own technology survey notes that 2D CAD drafting roles are shrinking at practices that have moved to full BIM workflows — a displacement that started before generative AI and is now accelerating.

What resists: the stamp and the liability behind it, site conditions nobody drew, a client who trusts you with their money, and judgment about what is actually buildable here. Those are the things to be building toward.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Moderate, and propped open by licensure — with a caveat covered under the question the profession hasn't answered.

The AXP requires logged experience hours under a licensed practitioner, which gives firms an institutional reason to employ and supervise candidates. That is the same mechanism protecting nursing, accounting and engineering.

And the licensure pipeline has shrunk, which has pushed licensed salaries up faster in 2024 and 2025 than in most of the previous decade. Scarcity at the licensed end is real.

But "propped open" hides a fork worth seeing now. The seat that is easiest to land is often production drafting — the 7.6 rung, and the work furthest into automation. Landing there because a seat is open is not the same as landing in the career. The way through is to aim at a seat that logs AXP hours under a licensed practitioner and puts you near the site — the experience that counts toward the stamp — rather than at whichever rung happens to be hiring fastest. A drafting desk that's hiring is not the same as a path to the signature.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

For construction administration substantially; for design work much less.

Site visits, commissioning, inspection and snagging cannot be done remotely. This is why the site-based track scores best in the profession.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

Yes — a client betting several million on a building wants a named human answerable for it, and liability follows the signature. Which means the fastest way to become protected is to get closer to the seat that carries it.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

Comprehensively. All fifty states require architects to be licensed, and certain drawings must be signed by one. The question the profession hasn't answered, below, explains why this protection is more fragile than it looks.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

Frequently. Every site, every program, every client is different, and the consequences of getting it wrong are physical and expensive. The distance between a standard-case drawing and a genuinely novel site is the distance you're trying to close.

The question the profession hasn't answered

This deserves its own section, because architecture is where it bites hardest of any career in this index.

The stamp is a legal monopoly, and like accounting's CPA pathway, architecture's licensure does something extra: **it mandates logged experience hours under a licensed practitioner.** Firms must employ and supervise candidates for the profession to replenish itself. That props the on-ramp open.

But what happens *inside* those hours has changed.

A candidate who spends the AXP directing generative tools and reviewing output accumulates the same hours as one who spent them drawing by hand. Are they building the same judgment?

Licensure certifies that someone has done the time. It assumes the time teaches. If the content of those years shifts from producing work to supervising work, the assumption may quietly stop holding — and the license would continue certifying something it no longer measures.

This sorts the professions in a way worth carrying elsewhere. In nursing, medicine and the trades, mandated experience hours are hands-on by necessity — you cannot supervise your way through clinical hours or an apprenticeship. In architecture, accounting and engineering, the mandated hours are desk-based, and desk work is exactly what is changing.

Architecture is the sharpest case of the three, because a larger share of the traditional AXP was drafting and documentation than in either of the others.

We rate the protection 8.5 because it is currently doing its job. We flag it as the factor most likely to be hollowed out from the inside rather than repealed.

The honest problem, and it isn't AI

Architecture requires the longest path to licensure of any design profession, and the pay does not correspond.

- **Eight to thirteen years** from starting high school to licensure, depending on route
- A five-year B.Arch is the most direct path; an M.Arch adds time for career changers
- The AXP experience requirement, then six ARE exam divisions — most candidates take 18 to 30 months just to pass the exams, at roughly $1,500–$2,000 in fees on top of tuition
- Median architect pay sits around **$99,270** according to BLS, with projected growth of 4–5%

Now the comparison that matters, and it's uncomfortable. Construction managers and engineers reach broadly similar salaries by materially shorter routes — and in our index, construction management scores 3.3 and licensed engineering 4.0 against architecture's 5.0.

Shorter path. Better protection. Comparable money.

That is not an argument against architecture — and it's least relevant to someone already on the path, where the length is largely behind or already committed. It's the argument for finishing what the length buys: the license.

The bright spot in the pay data, and it's the one to act on. The AIA's Compensation Report — covering 13,227 positions across 817 firms — finds licensure is the single largest salary multiplier in the profession: unlicensed professionals in their first five years earn roughly $52,000–$78,000, and licensure lifts that to $78,000–$105,000, an 18–35% increase.

The license is the product. Everything in this guide points at completing it.

What the trend shows

Licensed architecture: 4.3 → 4.6 → 5.0. Up 0.7.

Production drafting: 6.1 → 7.0 → 7.6. Up 1.5 — more than double the pace.

The gap widened from 1.8 points to 2.6. And the drafting displacement is visible in the pay data as well as ours: 2D CAD drafters average $48,000–$58,000 and the role is shrinking, while BIM technicians with three to five years of project experience command $58,000–$78,000 because demand exceeds supply.

Even inside the exposed tier, the split is between operating a tool and understanding a model.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Regulatory / licensing	Strong	**Most durable — with a caveat**	Moves at the speed of legislation. But see the question the profession hasn't answered, on what logged hours now contain.
Human trust / accountability	Strong	**Durable**	Clients want a named human answerable for a building.
Judgment under novelty	Strong	**Eroding slowly**	Site-specific judgment resists; standard-case design does not.
Physical / embodied	Real for site work	**Durable for construction administration**	Construction sites are among the hardest environments for automation.

The honest read. Architecture's protections are genuine, and they concentrate at the licensed, site-attending end. A student who completes the license and stays close to buildings is well positioned. One who stops at production work is in the most exposed part of the profession — which is why the direction you steer matters more than where you happen to start.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Drawing the set	Specifying it, then checking what was generated
Producing three design options	Choosing among fifty generated ones
Rendering by hand	Rendering instantly; judging what to show
Checking code manually	Verifying automated compliance output
Learning the craft by drafting for years	Learning it… some other way, still unresolved
Signing the drawings	**Unchanged**

One consequence worth naming. The value moves upstream — toward specifying the problem and judging the answer, away from producing the artefact. That's good news for architects who want to be responsible for buildings, and less good for anyone who chose architecture because they love drawing. Which means the people who go out of their way to understand construction — not just produce drawings — have an edge that's about to get scarcer.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Site judgment** — reading actual conditions against what the drawings claim. The least automatable thing in the profession. 2. **Accountability** — carrying the stamp and the liability. 3. **Design judgment on genuine novelty** — an unusual program, a difficult site, a constraint nobody has solved this way before. 4. **Client and stakeholder handling** — architecture is a coordination profession as much as a design one. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated design is buildable on screen and not in reality.

Notably absent: drafting speed, rendering skill and software fluency in any particular package. These were the traditional markers of a strong graduate and are the fastest-depreciating. If your current value is mostly on that second list, the work is to shift it onto the first.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: curiosity and adaptability. The specific tools — the BIM platform, the rendering engine, the generative-design plugin — will turn over many times across a career. The architects who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about how a building comes together and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they trained on. In a profession where the drafting rung is automating fastest, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what firms are hiring *for*: the trajectory toward the stamp, not fluency in this year's software.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The work is genuinely distinctive, and it's why people persist through a long path. You make things that exist for decades, that people occupy, and that shape how they feel. Very few careers offer that at all.

- **Median pay around $99,270**, above the median for all occupations
- **Roughly 7,800–12,100 annual openings**, with employment projected to grow 4–5%
- Licensure lifts pay 18–35%, the largest single multiplier in the profession
- **The licensure pipeline has shrunk**, pushing licensed salaries up faster than in most of the previous decade
- **Specialization pays sharply**: healthcare architecture commands an 18–30% premium, and data center and laboratory design a 20–35% premium — the AI buildout creating architectural demand in the same way it created electrical demand

Small firms pay slightly below market and offer faster advancement, more varied work and more creative autonomy — a genuine trade-off rather than simply worse.

What's genuinely hard about it

The length, covered under the honest problem, and it is the dominant issue.

The work is less creative than students expect. Most architects spend significant time on technical documentation rather than design, especially early on. Only senior designers and principals spend the majority of their time on creative work.

Hours during deadlines are long — 50 to 70 hours a week is common in crunch periods.

Pay compression between levels is a recognized cause of senior attrition, according to industry compensation analysis: the gap between a mid-level and a senior architect is often smaller than the difference in responsibility.

And geography matters enormously. West Coast pay runs around 25% above national average and the South around 6% below, so the same qualification produces very different outcomes depending on where someone practices.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Architecture tends to suit people who:

- **Want to make things that persist** — the single most-cited reason people stay
- **Can hold a long horizon.** The rewards arrive late, and the first decade is documentation.
- **Enjoy constraint** — code, budget, physics, client. Architecture is design inside hard limits.
- **Are comfortable coordinating people who disagree** — engineers, contractors, clients, planners
- **Can absorb criticism of work they care about**

It's harder for people who:

- Expect **creative work early**. It arrives around year eight to twelve.
- Need **strong early earnings**
- Dislike **documentation and regulation**, which is most of the early job
- Are drawn to the **image** of architecture rather than the practice

If some of that second list sounds like you, it isn't a reason to abandon the path — it's a reason to steer toward the parts of it that fit, and to get to the license that gives you optionality, which is what the rest of this does.

What else is moving this market

Construction cycles drive everything. Architecture is more cyclical than engineering and much more so than healthcare or education.

Sustainability and retrofit are growing, driven by regulation rather than technology, and sustainable design specialists earn a 15–25% premium.

And the data center and laboratory boom is a genuine tailwind — the highest specialization premium in the profession, and directly downstream of the same AI buildout that threatens other careers.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: generative design, automated compliance checking and instant visualization are established in large practices. The people who can direct and verify them are not. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a live placement or first job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE ARCHITECT LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when a generated design is buildable on screen and not in reality. This requires understanding construction well enough to catch a plausible error, which is why site exposure matters more than it used to.

2. Specify. Framing the constraint set precisely enough that generated options are usable. The skill has moved upstream from drawing to briefing.

3. Judge applicability. Knowing whether a standard solution fits this site, this contractor, this jurisdiction.

4. Own the stamp. Everything here points at licensure. Start the AXP deliberately and finish it.

5. Bridge model and site. Being the person who connects what the model says with what the site shows. That is where the two protected tracks meet.

All five are available to you *now* — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where an architecture degree can take you later

Broader than people assume: practice and design leadership, construction administration, project and construction management, urban design and planning, sustainability and building performance, computational design, real estate development, and heritage and conservation.

The pattern in this index holds: the further from the site and the signature, the higher the exposure. Visualization and drafting-adjacent roles score worst; construction administration and development score best. That pattern is the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Architecture is a spread from 4.7 to 7.6, and where you land inside it is decided mostly by things still in front of you. Nearly all of them point the same way: toward the site and the stamp.

If you're still in the degree or training

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. The license is the whole game. Production drafting (7.6) and BIM coordination (6.7) are the exposed end and furthest into automation already. The protected destinations — construction administration (4.7), licensed architect (5.0), the specialist tracks (5.5) — are reached through the AXP and the ARE, not by stopping at production work. If you haven't set the AXP as the destination, this is the single highest-leverage decision left, and every choice should be aimed at the signature. Check accreditation against the jurisdiction where you intend to practice; a degree that doesn't map onto licensure there is a longer path than it looks.

2. Site exposure and building science, while they're still free. Construction administration scores 4.7 precisely because site visits, commissioning and snagging can't be done remotely — and site judgment is exactly what verification later depends on. Chase site time, not just studio and office work; it's better and rarer. Take building science and computational design seriously too: those are the specialist tracks that carry premiums (5.5), and they age far better than software fluency. It's far cheaper to acquire this in the degree than to bolt on later.

3. A seat that logs AXP hours, earlier than feels comfortable. The through-line of this whole index is that roles near the site and the signature score better than roles that only produce drawings — and the on-ramp to that is supervised experience under a licensed practitioner. A placement near the site, a role that starts your AXP hours, exposure to a real client and a real building: that is the experience that separates the protected end from the exposed floor, and in architecture the logged hours are the mechanism that keeps the door open at all.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early-career architecture titles are also the most exposed.

- **"Production drafting" and drafting-adjacent visualization roles *are* the 7.6.** They're the default first destinations and the automating layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.

- **Aim at construction administration and a design seat under a licensed practitioner (4.7, 5.0).** More protected, closer to the site and the client, and the seats where AXP hours actually accumulate toward the stamp.
- **Get onto a seat that logs AXP hours.** A first role that generates supervised experience toward licensure — ideally near the site — is worth more than a better-paid drafting seat that leads nowhere near the signature. A seat that pays now but doesn't count toward the stamp is choosing the 7.6 tier, however it's titled.
- **Chase the seat closest to the site and the signature.** Construction administration over back-office drafting, a role near the client over pure production — even at a smaller firm, where responsibility and site contact tend to arrive sooner. The BIM route pays faster (BIM technicians $58,000–$78,000 against drafters' $48,000–$58,000), but faster earnings in an exposed lane is not the same as a path to the 18–35% the license carries.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't undo the last few years, but you can be the architect who *directs* these tools rather than competes with them. The five capabilities above — verify, specify, judge applicability, own the stamp, bridge model and site — are all available right now, inside a current placement or a first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is verification: be the person who catches the generated design that's buildable on screen and not in reality. That requires understanding construction well enough to spot a plausible error — which is why site exposure matters more than it used to, and it's the skill the licensed tier is built on. You can start building it this term, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in architecture is built here, in these habits and choices, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree or training; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree / training — build toward the stamp

- **Treat the license as the product, not the degree.** The protection in architecture lives at the licensed and site-based tiers (construction administration 4.7, licensed architect 5.0), not in production drafting (7.6) or BIM coordination (6.7). Aim every choice at the signature.

- **Check accreditation against the jurisdiction where you intend to practice.** A degree that doesn't map onto licensure where you'll work is a longer path than it looks.
- **Chase site exposure, not just studio and office time.** Site visits, commissioning and snagging are the least automatable work in the profession — construction administration scores 4.7 precisely because it can't be done remotely. Seek it out; it's better and rarer than office placement.
- **Take building science and computational design seriously.** Those are the specialist tracks that carry premiums (5.5), and they're what verification later depends on. A curriculum organised around software packages is training for the exposed tier.
- **Get fluent with generative design and automated compliance as a professional, not a shortcut.** Learn to specify the constraint set and to catch a design that's buildable on screen and not in reality — verification is the skill that survives.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The BIM platform and the rendering engine will turn over repeatedly; the architect who re-tools fastest, and stays genuinely interested in how a building comes together, compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet construction management (3.3) and licensed engineering (4.0) if you're reconsidering — not as consolation prizes but because they reach comparable money by shorter routes with better scores.

During the job hunt — aim for the stamp, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Construction administration, a design seat under a licensed practitioner, a specialist track in building science or computational design — not "any drawing job," which too often points at the 7.6 rung.
- **Read the title, not just the offer.** Production drafting and drafting-adjacent visualization are the automating layer (7.6). If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. A practice still running a large production-drafting intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut first once it catches up. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
- **Get onto a seat that logs AXP hours.** A first role that generates supervised experience toward licensure — under a licensed practitioner, ideally near the site — is worth more than a better-paid drafting seat that leads nowhere near the stamp.
- **Prefer the seat closest to the site and the signature.** Construction administration over back-office drafting, a design role near the client over pure production — proximity to the building someone stands behind is proximity to the protection.

- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're building the job around generative design and verification, or waiting to be forced to, tells you if the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.
- **Weigh trajectory over starting salary.** The BIM route pays faster (BIM technicians \$58,000–\$78,000 against drafters' \$48,000–\$58,000), but the answer to the entry salary is the license and the 18–35% it carries, not the highest first-year number in an exposed lane.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Architects — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — *US Bureau of Labor Statistics*. Primary source and free: median pay, projected growth, annual openings and licensure requirements. Read the **Construction Managers** and **Civil Engineers** entries alongside it to see where the adjacent professions sit.
- **NCARB — becoming an architect** — the National Council of Architectural Registration Boards is the authority on licensure. The AXP and ARE requirements, timelines and fees come from here rather than from any university prospectus.
- **How long does it take to become an architect?** — a clear breakdown of the eight-to-thirteen-year path, the exam structure and the real costs.

The counterargument — read this one:

> The strongest case against our 5.0 is that we are **crediting the stamp with protection that the market is quietly removing**.
>
> Architecture is unusual in that its most exposed tier — drafting and documentation — is also the tier most easily offshored. Firms have been sending BIM and drafting work overseas for years, and generative tools accelerate rather than initiate that. On this reading, the erosion of the entry tier is a labor-cost story with an AI accelerant, and our framework over-attributes it to the technology.
>
> There's a version that cuts the other way too: if the licensure pipeline keeps shrinking while construction demand holds, licensed architects become scarcer and better paid — which the 2024–25 salary data already shows. On that reading our 5.0 may be too *high* for the licensed tier.
>
> **Where we land:** we think both are partly right, and they affect different tiers. Offshoring and automation compound at the drafting end, which is why it scores 7.6. Scarcity protects the licensed end, which is why it scores 5.0 rather than 6. What we're watching is

> the licensure rate — if the proportion of graduates who qualify keeps falling, the profession has a pipeline problem that will eventually show up as either higher pay or lower standards, and we'll report which.

Bottom line

Architecture is the field where what you *do with the degree* matters more than the degree itself — and the honest problems have nothing to do with AI. That's the whole reason being already in it is not a problem: the decisive moves — which end you steer toward, whether you finish the license — were always going to happen from here.

The protected end is genuinely protected. The stamp is a legal monopoly, site work cannot be done remotely, and clients want a named human answerable for a building. Those hold.

The length is the real cost, and it's largely committed. This is the longest path to licensure of any design profession — eight to thirteen years — and the pay does not correspond to that length. Construction managers and engineers reach similar money by shorter routes, and in this index they score better: 3.3 and 4.0 against architecture's 5.0. But that comparison is a reason to finish what the length buys, not to abandon it: the license is worth 18–35%.

And the logged-hours question is sharper here than anywhere. The AXP mandates supervised experience, which protects the on-ramp — but a larger share of those hours was traditionally drafting than in accounting or engineering, and drafting is exactly what is automating. Which is the argument for filling those hours near the site, not the desk.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Treat the license as the product, not the qualification you happen to be earning. Chase site exposure over studio and office time. Specialize deliberately — healthcare, laboratory and data center work carry the largest premiums, and sustainability is growing. And build real AI fluency — verification above all — inside whatever role you're in now, because that's the differentiator this profession rewards.

And one honest thing worth holding onto through the long middle. You make things that stand for decades and that people live inside. Very few careers offer that, and no score measures it. That's what the length is buying — so finish it, and aim at the end of the profession where it counts.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in it or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which track are you on — or aiming at — and does it point at the *site and the signature* (construction administration, licensed architect) or at *the desk* (production drafting, BIM coordination)? 2. Looking at the score table, which destination are you currently pointed at, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. Is the AXP set as your destination, with a plan for the hours and the exams — or is licensure still something to get around to later?

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected seat you could realistically aim for from where you are now — construction administration, a design seat under a licensed practitioner — and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: how much site exposure and building science are you actually getting, and is there more you could add before it's no longer free? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a seat that logs AXP hours on purpose, or applying to whatever's open? Does the first role you're chasing count toward the stamp?

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — verify, specify, judge applicability, own the stamp, bridge model and site — which one could you visibly demonstrate within the next few months? 8. Can you point to a moment where you caught a generated design that was buildable on screen but not in reality? If not, where's the easiest place to start building that skill?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** visit a construction site, not just a building, and find an architect five to ten years in — ask what they actually do all day, and how long licensure took them. 10. If the first offer that comes is a production-drafting role, what's your plan — take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, or hold out for something closer to the site and the stamp? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For architecture specifically, we've flagged that the profession's most significant problems — the length of the path and pay relative *to that length — sit entirely outside what our six factors measure.*

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Architecture

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

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1. The formula

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Risk = 0.35 × Automatability
     + 0.15 × EntryErosion
     + 0.15 × (10 − Physical)
     + 0.15 × (10 − Trust)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Regulatory)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Judgment)
```

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

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2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent*, *where being wrong is costly*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

CONSTRUCTION ADMINISTRATION / SITE — 4.7 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	7.4	8.1	**9.1**	3.18
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	**3.8**	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.38
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.15
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**4.7 → 4.7**

LICENSED ARCHITECT / DESIGN LEAD — 5.0 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	7.8	8.5	**9.4**	3.29
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.2	3.6	**4.0**	0.6
Physical / embodied	15%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.53
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.15
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**4.99 → 5.0**

SPECIALIST (SUSTAINABILITY, COMPUTATIONAL) — 5.5 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	8.1	9.1	**9.8**	3.43
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	3.8	**4.2**	0.63
Physical / embodied	15%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.75
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**5.51 → 5.5**

TECHNICAL / BIM COORDINATION — 6.7 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.8	8.0	**8.9**	3.11
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.0	**5.5**	0.82
Physical / embodied	15%	2.5	2.5	**2.5**	1.12
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.45
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
				Total	**6.69 → 6.7**

PRODUCTION DRAFTING — 7.6 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.1	8.3	**9.7**	3.39
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.5	**7.2**	1.08
Physical / embodied	15%	2.0	2.0	**2.0**	1.2
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.6
				Total	**7.6 → 7.6**

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Construction administration / site

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	7.4	3.0	0.95	**4.0**
2025	8.1	3.4	0.95	**4.3**
Fall 2026	9.1	3.8	0.95	**4.7**

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.59** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.